

New York Stories: Lucy Sante [C1]

Abbiamo incontrato la saggista e scrittrice di origine belga per parlare dell'inglese, del suo lavoro e della sua vita personale... ma anche di true crime!

Lucy Sante is a Belgian-born American writer and photographer who emigrated to New Jersey in the early 1960s. As a child, she only spoke French, but ended up excelling in English to the point that she taught [essay writing](#) at New York's Bard College for nearly twenty-five years. A frequent contributor to The New York Review of Books, Sante's own publications include a biography of New York City from the early 19th to the 20th century called Low Life: [Lures](#) and [Snares](#) of Old New York (1991); a collection of photographs of suicides and homicide victims from 1914 to 1918 called Evidence (1992) and a book of essays called Kill All Your [Darlings](#): Pieces 1990-2005 (2007). In 2002, the writer worked as a historical consultant on Martin Scorsese's film Gangs of New York.

TRANSITIONS

Sante's most recent book is what she calls a "trans memoir." Entitled I Heard Her Call My Name: A Memoir of Transition it describes how in 2021 at the age of sixty-eight, Sante transitioned, changing her name from Luc to Lucy. The book has met [with](#) significant acclaim and was a finalist in the autobiography category of the Pulitzer Prize. To find out more about her life and writing, Speak Up met [with](#) Sante. As she explained, she responded to the challenge of having to learn English [from scratch](#) by trying to be better at it than the Americans. **Lucy Sante (American accent):** It was natural for me to write in English because I was surrounded by English and, you know, there was this lively literary culture in New York that I wanted to join. My English has accumulated a lot of depth to it, you know, and it's interesting because English is a language I've dominated, but French is the language that reaches me emotionally most strongly; it's after all the language of the [nursery](#) and so I'm much more vulnerable in French than I am in English.

EVOLVING CITYSCAPE

In her book *Low Life*, the writer explores New York City's development through the eyes of its poorest residents. The relationship between economics and nationality is ever present, says Sante, which is why the Hispanic community is prominent in the book, as it considers a period of history from the 19th century to the early 20th century, but would not have been were it considering a later period. **Lucy Sante:** *Low Life* pertains to the Hispanic population simply because they are at the bottom of the ladder and they have very little money. It's the world seen from the point of view of the working class and crime is unavoidable in the lives of the poor. Every neighbourhood I moved into in New York was majority Dominican, and wasn't by the time I moved out, you know. So I'm part of the process of gentrification. West Harlem was African-American until twenty-thirty years ago and now it's almost completely Dominican. The Puerto Ricans, they're almost invisible as a group in New York now, because they've all risen in the world and moved out to the suburbs.

CREATIVE DECLINE

With gentrification, it is harder for artists and musicians to be experimental. This has led to institutionalisation that limits the arts to those wealthy enough to pay for education, as she explains. **Lucy Sante:** So many things that people can't take a chance on anymore so a whole wide field of experimentation is lost. So much has been shut down, young people are forced to go through institutional channels, people stay in school a lot longer. I taught writing for twenty-seven years. For a long time my course was called 'The Essay'. And at Bard where I taught for twenty-three of those years, there were only three of us teaching writing, and then somehow, mysteriously, it became a department with, like, twenty-two people and essay writing in general has become much more popular and so people have attempted to fit laws onto it and what it can do and what it should do and... it just closes doors, in my opinion.

SCOTTISH CRIME

Sante is currently writing a book about iconic New York band The Velvet Underground. As she explains, she became fascinated by the club scene in New York in the late 1970s and early 1980s, at a time when the city was rife [with](#) crime. We asked her about her interest in true crime podcasts and series. As she [points out](#), one of the pioneers of the true crime genre was a professional lawyer who lived and worked in early 20th century Edinburgh. **Lucy Sante:** There are some great true crime writers. The great master is a Scottish writer named William Roughead. It was his job to [attend](#) very prominent trials held in Edinburgh and make an official [account](#) for the government, but the language is just extraordinary. It's very human, it gets under the skin of the accused; he is kind of a novelist in his way. So, there's [there are] a few people like that.

WILLIAM ROUGHEAD: TRUE CRIME PIONEER

Born in Edinburgh in 1870, William Roughead was a lawyer and a member of the Society of Writers to Her Majesty's [Signet](#), an historic group of Scottish solicitors entitled to supervise use of the King's [Signet](#), or seal. From 1901, Roughead established himself as an unofficial historian of crime, [attending](#) almost every prominent murder trial at the High Court of Justiciary and publishing brilliant [accounts](#) of cases, initially in the monthly legal journal The Juridical Review and then anthologies of essays, including Twelve Scots Trials (1914), In Queer Street (1932) and Murder and More Murder (1939). Roughead, much admired by the American author Henry James, wrote in a style that combined intelligence, [wit](#), scepticism and storytelling. In 1928, he and Arthur Conan Doyle helped [secure](#) the freedom of Oscar Slater, the victim of a [miscarriage of justice](#). According to author Joyce Carol Oates: "Roughead's influence was enormous, and since his time "true crime" has become a crowded, flourishing field."

A GIANT SECRET

In her recent memoir, published in 2024, Sante explores gender and tries to get to grips with why she decided to transition at an advanced age. **Lucy Sante:** By and large, I don't think that there are many gender issues in my work... I was never very good at being a man. It's certainly changed my relation to other people. I'm much more open to people, I'm not crippled by shyness the way I was for sixty-six years, and part of that is just having dropped this giant secret that I carried like a giant stone for decades.

Glossary

- **Snares** = trappole
- **Darlings** = cari
- **nursery** = infanzia
- **unavoidable** = inevitabile
- **fit laws onto it** = adattarvi delle leggi
- **secure** = garantire, assicurare
- **crippled** = paralizzata
- **shyness** = timidezza
- **essay writing** = scrittura di saggi
- **shut down** = chiudere
- **account** = resoconto
- **wit** = arguzia
- **get to grips with** = affrontare, venire a capo
- **ever present** = sempre presente
- **take a chance on** = rischiare, scommettere
- **rife with** = piena di
- **attend** = assistere
- **Signet** = sigillo
- **miscarriage of justice** = errore giudiziario
- **By and large** = in generale
- **gender issues** = questioni di genere
- **Lures** = esche
- **from scratch** = da zero
- **at the bottom of the ladder** = ai piedi della scala
- **points out** = segnalare
- **dropped** = lasciar cadere